

Rubáiyát of Doc Sifers

James Whitcomb Riley

Project Gutenberg

Rubáiyát of Doc Sifers

James Whitcomb Riley



Project Gutenberg

The Project Gutenberg eBook of Rubáiyát of Doc Sifers

This eBook is for the use of anyone anywhere in the United States and most other parts of the world at no cost and with almost no restrictions whatsoever. You may copy it, give it away or re-use it under the terms of the Project Gutenberg License included with this eBook or online at www.gutenberg.org. If you are not located in the United States, you will have to check the laws of the country where you are located before using this eBook.

Title: Rubáiyát of Doc Sifers

Author: James Whitcomb Riley

Illustrator: C. M. Relyea

Release date: June 22, 2010 [eBook #32944]

Language: English

Other information and formats: www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/32944

Credits: Produced by David Edwards, Therese Wright and the Online Distributed Proofreading Team at <http://www.pgdp.net> (This file was produced from images generously made available by The Internet Archive)

*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK RUBÁIYÁT OF
DOC SIFERS ***

RUBÁIYÁT OF DOC SIFERS BY JAMES WHITCOMB RILEY

Other Books by
James Whitcomb Riley



POEMS HERE AT HOME.

NEIGHBORLY POEMS.

SKETCHES IN PROSE AND OCCASIONAL
VERSES.

AFTERWHILES.

PIPES O' PAN (Prose and Verse).

RHYMES OF CHILDHOOD.

FLYING ISLANDS OF THE NIGHT.

OLD-FASHIONED ROSES (English Edition).

GREEN FIELDS AND RUNNING BROOKS.

ARMAZINDY.

A CHILD-WORLD.

AN OLD SWEETHEART OF MINE.



RUBÁIYÁT OF DOC SIFERS

BY JAMES WHITCOMB RILEY

ILLUSTRATED

BY

C. M. RELYEA



**PUBLISHED BY THE CENTURY CO.
NEW YORK M DCCC XC VII**

**Copyright, 1897,
BY THE CENTURY CO.**

**Copyright, 1897,
BY JAMES WHITCOMB RILEY**

THE DE VINNE PRESS.

TO

DR. FRANKLIN W. HAYS

**THE LOYAL CHUM OF MY LATEST YOUTH
AND LIKE FRIEND AND COMRADE STILL
WITH ALL GRATEFUL AFFECTION OF**

THE AUTHOR.

We found him in that far-away that yet to us seems near—

*We vagrants of but yesterday when idlest youth was here,—
When lightest song and laziest mirth possessed us through and
through,
And all the dreamy summer-earth seemed drugged with morning
dew:*

*When our ambition scarce had shot a stalk or blade indeed:
Yours,—choked as in the garden-spot you still deferred to "weed":
Mine,—but a pipe half-cleared of pith—as now it flats and whines
In sympathetic cadence with a hiccough in the lines.*

*Aye, even then—o timely hour!—the high gods did confer
In our behalf:—and, clothed in power, lo, came their courier—
Not winged with flame nor shod with wind,—but ambling down the
pike,
Horseback, with saddlebags behind, and guise all human-like.*

*And it was given us to see, beneath his rustic rind,
A native force and mastery of such inspiring kind,
That half unconsciously we made obeisance.—smiling, thus
His soul shone from his eyes and laid its glory over us.*

.

*Though, faring still that far-away that yet to us seems near,
His form, through mists of yesterday, fades from the vision here,
Forever as he rides, it is in retinue divine,—
The hearts of all his time are his, with your hale heart and mine.*



RUBÁIYÁT OF DOC SIFERS

I

Ef you don't know DOC SIFERS I'll jes argy, here and now,
You've bin a mighty little while about here, anyhow!
'Cause Doc he's rid these roads and woods—er *swum* 'em, now and
then—
And practised in this neighborhood sence hain't no tellin' when!

II

In radius o' fifteen mile'd, all p'int's o' compass round,
No man er woman, chick er child, er team, on top o' ground,
But knows *him*—yes, and got respects and likin' fer him, too,
Fer all his so-to-speak dee-fects o' genius showin' through!

III

Some claims he's absent-minded; some has said they wuz afeard
To take his powders when he come and dosed 'em out, and 'peared
To have his mind on somepin' else—like County Ditch, er some
New way o' tannin' mussrat-pelts, er makin' butter come.

IV

He's cur'ous—they hain't no mistake about it!—but he's got

Enough o'
extr
y
brai
ns to
mak
e a
jury
—
like
as
not.

They's no
desc
ribin
,
Sifer
s,—
fer,
whe
n all
is

said and done,

He's jes *hisse'f* *Doc Sifers*—ner they hain't no other one!



V

Doc's allus sociable, polite, and 'greeable, you'll find—
Pervidin' ef you strike him right and nothin' on his mind,—
Like in some *hurry*, when they've sent fer Sifers *quick*, you see,
To 'tend some sawmill-accident, er picnic jamboree;

VI

Er when the lightnin' 's struck some hare-brained harvest-hand; er in
Some 'tempt o' suicidin'—where they'd ort to try ag'in!

I've *knowed* Doc haul up from a trot and talk a' hour er two
When railyly he'd a-ort o' not a-stopped fer "*Howdy-do!*"



VII

And then, I've
met him
'long the
road, *a-*
lopin',—
starin'
straight
Ahead,—and yit
he never
knowed
me when I
hollered
"*Yate,*
Old Saddlebags!"
all hearty-
like, er
"*Who you*
goin' to
kill?"

And he'd say nothin'—only hike on faster, starin' still!



VIII

I'd bin insulted, many a time, ef I jes wuzn't shore
Doc didn't mean a thing. And I'm not tetchy any more
Sence that-air day, ef he'd a-jes a-stopped to jaw with *me*,
They'd bin a little dorter less in my own fambily!

IX

Times *now*, at home, when Sifers' name comes up, I jes *let on*,
You know, 'at I think Doc's to *blame*, the way he's bin and gone
And disapp'inted folks—'Ll-jee-mun-nee! you'd ort to then
Jes hear my wife light into me—"ongratefulest o' men!"



X

'Mongst *all* the women—mild er rough, splendifferous er plain,
Er them *with* sense, er not enough to come in out the rain,—
Jes ever' shape and build and style o' women, fat er slim—
They all like Doc, and got a smile and pleasant word fer *him*!

XI

Ner hain't no horse I've
ever saw but
what'll neigh and
try
To sidle up to him, and
paw, and sense
him, ear-and-eye:
Then jes a tetch o' Doc's
old pa'm, to pat
'em, er to shove
Along their nose—and
they're as ca'm as
any cooin' dove!



XII

And same with *dogs*,—
take any breed,
er strain, er
pedigree,
Er racial caste 'at can't
concede no use fer you er me,—
They'll putt all predju-dice aside in *Doc's* case and go in
Kahoots with him, as satisfied as he wuz kith-and-kin!

XIII

And Doc's a wonder, trainin' pets!—He's got a chicken-hawk,
In kind o' half-cage, where he sets out in the gyarden-walk,
And got that wild bird trained so tame, he'll loose him, and he'll fly
Clean to the woods!—Doc calls his name—and he'll come, by-and-
by!

XIV

Some says no money down
ud buy that bird o'
Doc.—Ner no
Inducement to the *bird*, says I,
'at *he'd* let *Sifers* go!
And Doc *he* say 'at *he's*
content—long as a
bird o' prey
Kin 'bide *him*, it's a
compliment, and takes
it thataway.

XV

But, gittin' back to
docterin'—all the sick
and in distress,
And old and pore, and weak
and small, and lone
and motherless,—
I jes tell *you* I 'preciate the
man 'at 's got the love
To "go ye forth and ministrate!" as Scriptur' tells us of.



XVI

Dull times, Doc jes *mianders* round, in that old rig o' his:
And hain't no tellin' where he's bound ner guessin' where he is;
He'll drive, they tell, jes thataway fer maybe six er eight
Days at a stretch; and neighbors say he's bin clean round the State.

XVII

He picked a' old tramp up, one trip, 'bout eighty mile'd from here,

And fetched him home and k-yored his hip, and kep' him 'bout a
year;
And feller said—in all *his* ja'nts round this terreschul ball
'At no man wuz a *circumstance* to *Doc*!—he topped 'em all!—

XVIII

Said, bark o' trees 's a'
open book to Doc,
and vines and moss
He read like writin'—with
a look knowed
ever' dot and cross:
Said, stars at night wuz jes
as good 's a
compass: said, he
s'pose
You couldn't lose Doc in
the woods the
darkest night that
blows!



XIX

Said, Doc'll tell you, purty
clos't, by underbresh and plants,
How fur off *warter* is,—and 'most perdict the sort o' chance
You'll have o' findin' *fish*; and how they're liable to *bite*,
And whether they're a-bitin' now, er only after night.

XX

And, whilse we're talkin' *fish*,—I mind they formed a fishin'-crowd
(When folks *could* fish 'thout gittin' *fined*, and seinin' wuz allowed!)
O' leadin' citizens, you know, to go and seine "Old Blue"—

But hadn't no big seine, and so—w'y, what wuz they to do?...

XXI

And Doc he say he thought 'at *he* could *knit* a stitch er two—
"Bring the *materials* to me—'at's all I'm astin' you!"
And down he sets—six weeks, i jing! and knits that seine plum done

—
Made corks too, brails and ever'thing—good as a boughten one!

XXII

Doc's *public* sperit
—when the
sick 's not
takin' *all* his
time

And he's got *some*
fer politics
—is simple
yit sublime:

—
He'll *talk* his
principles—
and they air
honest;—
but the sly
Friend strikes him
first,
election-day,
he'd
'commodate, er die!



XXIII

And yit, though Doc, as all men knows, is square straight up and
down,
That vote o' his is—well, I s'pose—the cheapest one in town;—
A fact 'at's sad to verify, as could be done on oath—
I've voted Doc myse'f—*And I was criminal fer both!*

XXIV

You kin corrupt the *ballot-box*—corrupt *yourse'f*, as well—
Corrupt *some* neighbors,—but old Doc's as oncorruptible
As Holy Writ. So putt a pin right there!—Let *Sifers* be,
I jucks! he wouldn't vote agin his own worst inimy!

XXV

When Cynthy Eubanks laid so low with fever, and Doc Glenn
Told Euby Cynth 'ud haf to go—they sends fer *Sifers* then!...
Doc sized the case: "She's starved," says he, "fer *warter*—yes, and
meat!
The treatment 'at she'll git from *me* 's all she kin drink and eat!"

XXVI

He orders Euby then to split some wood, and take and build
A fire in kitchen-stove, and git a young spring-chicken killed;
And jes whirled in and th'owed his hat and coat there on the bed,
And warshed his hands and sailed in that-air kitchen, Euby said,

XXVII

And biled that chicken-broth, and got that dinner—all complete
And clean and crisp and good and hot as mortal ever eat!
And Cynth and Euby both'll say 'at Doc'll git as good
Meals-vittles up, jes any day, as any *woman* could!

XXVIII

Time Sister
Abbic
k tuk
so bad
with
striffe
n o'
the
lung,
P'tracted
Meeti
n',
where
she
had
jes
shoute
d,
praye
d and
sung



All winter long, through snow and thaw,—when Sifers come, says
he:
"No, M'lissy; don't poke out your raw and cloven tongue at me!—

XXIX

"I know, without no symptoms but them *injarubber-shoes*
You promised me to never putt a fool-foot in ner use
At purril o' your life!" he said. "And I won't save you *now*,
Unless—here on your dyin' bed—you consecrate your vow!"

XXX

Without a-claimin' *any creed*, Doc's rail religious views
Nobody knows—ner got no *need* o' knowin' whilse he choose
To be heerd not of man, ner raise no loud, vainglorious prayers
In crowded marts, er public ways, er—i jucks, *anywheres!*—



XXXI

'Less 'n it *is* away deep down in his own heart, at night,
Facin' the storm, when all the town's a-sleepin' snug and tight—
Him splashin' hence from scenes o' pride and sloth and gilded show,
To some pore sufferer's bedside o' anguish, don't you know!

XXXII

Er maybe dead o' *winter*—makes no odds to *Doc*,—he's got
To face the weather ef it takes the hide off! 'cause he'll not
Lie out o' goin' and p'tend he's sick hisse'f—like *some*
'At I could name 'at folks might send fer and they'd *never* come!

XXXIII

Like pore Phin Hoover—when he goes to that last dance o' his!
That Chris'mus when his feet wuz froze—and Doc saved all they is
Left of 'em—"Nough," as Phin say now, "to *track* me by, and be
A advertisement, anyhow, o' what Doc's done fer me!—

XXXIV

"When *he* come
 —knife-
 and-
 saw"—
 Phin say,
 "I
 knowed,
 ef I'd the
 spunk,
 'At Doc 'ud fix
 me up
 some way,
 ef nothin'
 but my
 trunk
 Wuz left, he'd
 fasten
 casters in,
 and have
 me, spick-
 and-span,
 A-skootin' round
 the streets ag'in as spry as any man!"



XXXV

Doc sees a patient's *got* to quit—he'll ease him down serene
 As dozin' off to sleep, and yit not dope him with mor-*pheen*.—
 He won't tell *what*—jes 'lows 'at he has "airn't the right to sing
 'O grave, where is thy victory! O death, where is thy sting!"

XXXVI

And, mind ye now!—it's not in scoff and scorn, by long degree,
 'At Doc gits things like that-un off: it's jes his *shority*
 And total faith in Life to Come,—w'y, "from that *Land o' Bliss*,"

He says, "we'll haf to
chuckle some, a-
lookin' back at
this!"



XXXVII

And, still in p'int, I mind, one *night o' 'nitiation* at

Some secert lodge, 'at Doc set right down on 'em, square and flat,
When they mixed up some Scriptur' and wuz *funnin'*-like—w'y, he
Lit in 'em with a rep'imand 'at ripped 'em, A to Z!

XXXVIII

And onc't—when ginerall loafin'-place wuz old Shoe-Shop—and all
The gang 'ud git in there and brace their backs ag'inst the wall
And *settle* questions that had went onsettled long enough,—
Like "wuz no Heav'n—ner no torment"—*jes talkin' awful rough!*



XXXIX

There wuz Sloke Haines and old Ike Knight and Coonrod Simmes
—all three
Ag'inst the Bible and the Light, and scoutin' Deity.
"Science," says Ike, "it *dimonstrates*—it takes nobody's word—
Scriptur' er not,—it '*vestigates* ef sich things could occurred!"

XL

Well, Doc he heerd this,—he'd drapped in a minute, fer to git
A tore-off heel pegged on agin,—and, as he stood on it

And stomped
and
grinned,
he
says to
Ike, "I
s'pose
now,
purty
soon

Some
lightni
n'-bug,
indign
ant-
like, 'll
"vestig
ate' the
moon!
...



XL I

"No, Ike," says Doc, "this world hain't saw no brains like yourn and mine

With sense enough to grasp a law 'at takes a brain divine.—
I've bared the thoughts of brains in doubt, and felt their finest pulse,

—
And mortal brains jes won't turn out omnipotent results!"

XL II

And Doc he's got respects to spare the *rich* as well as *pore*—
Says he, "I'd turn no *millionaire* onsheltered from my door."—
Says he, "What's wealth to him in quest o' *honest* friends to back
And love him fer *hisse'f*?—not jes because he's made his jack!"



XLIII

And childern.—*Childern?* Lawzy-day! Doc worships 'em!—You
call
Round at his house and *ast* 'em!—they're a-swarmin' there—that's
all!—
They're in his *Lib'ry*—in best room—in kitchen—fur and near,—
In office too, and, I p'sume, his operatin'-cheer!

XLIV

You know they's men 'at *bees* won't sting?—They's plaguey *few*,—
but Doc
He's one o' *them*.—And same, i jing! with *childern*;—they jes flock
Round Sifers *natchurl*!—in his lap, and in his pockets, too,
And in his old fur mitts and cap, and *heart* as warm and true!

XLV

It's cur'ous, too,—'cause Doc hain't got no childern of his own—
'Ceptin' the ones he's tuk and brought up, 'at's bin left alone.

And orphans when their
 father died, er
 mother,—and Doc he
 Has he'pped their dyin'
 satisfied.—"The
 child shall live with
 me



XLVI

"And Winniferd, my wife," he'd say, and stop right there, and cle'r
 His th'oat, and go on thinkin' way *some* mother-hearts down here
 Can't never feel *their own* babe's face a-pressin' 'em, ner make
 Their naked breasts a restin'-place fer any baby's sake.

XLVII

Doc's *Lib'ry*—as he calls it,—well, they's ha'f-a-dozen she'ves
 Jam-full o' books—I couldn't tell *how* many—count yourse'ves!
One whole she'f's Works on Medicine! and most the rest's about
 First Settlement, and Indians in here,—'fore we driv 'em out.—

XLVIII

And Plutarch's Lives—
 and life also o'
 Dan'el Boone,
 and this-
 Here Mungo Park, and
 Adam Poe—jes
 all the *lives* they
 is!
 And Doc's got all the
novels out,—by
 Scott and
 Dickison
 And Cooper.—And, I
 make no doubt,
 he's read 'em
 ever' one!



XLIX

Onc't, in his office,
 settin' there, with
 crowd o' eight er nine
 Old neighbors with the time to spare, and Doc a-feelin' fine,
 A man rid up from Rollins, jes fer Doc to write him out
 Some blame p'scription—done, I guess, in minute, nigh about.—



L

And *I* says, "Doc, you 'pear so spry, jes write me that recei't
You have fer bein' *happy* by,—fer that 'u'd shorely beat
Your *medicine!*" says I.—And quick as *s'cat!* Doc turned and writ
And handed me: "Go he'p the sick, and putt your heart in it."

LI

And then, "A-talkin' further 'bout that line o' thought," says he,
"Ef we'll jes do the work cut out and give' to you and me,
We'll lack no joy, ner appetite, ner all we'd ort to eat,
And sleep like childern ever' night—as puore and ca'm and sweet."

LII

Doc *has* bin 'cused o' *offishness* and lack o' talkin' free
And extry friendly; but he says, "I'm '*feard* o' talk," says he,—
"I've got," he says, "a natchurl turn fer talkin' fit to kill.—
The best and hardest thing to learn is trick o' keepin' still."

LIII

Doc *kin* smoke, and I s'pose he *might* drink licker—jes fer fun.
He says, "*You* smoke, *you* drink all right; but *I* don't—neether
 one"—
Says, "*I like* whiskey—'good old rye'—but like it in its place,
Like that-air warter in your eye, er nose there on your face."

LIV

Doc's bound to have his joke! The day he got that off on me
I jes had sold a load o' hay at "Scofield's Livery,"
And tolled Doc in the shed they kep' the hears't in, where I'd hid
The stuff 'at got me "out o' step," as Sifers said it did.

LV

Doc hain't, to say, no
 "rollin' stone," and
 yit he hain't no hand
Fer 'cumulatin'.—*Home's*
 his own, and scrap
 o' farmin'-land—
Enough to keep him out the
 way when folks is
 tuk down sick
The suddentest—'most any
 day they want him
 'special quick.



LVI

And yit Doc loves his
 practice; ner don't,
 wilful, want to
 slight
No call—no matter who—
 how fur away—er day er night.—
He loves his work—he loves his friends—June, Winter, Fall, and
 Spring:
His *lovin'*—facts is—never ends; he loves jes *ever'thing*....

LVII

'Cept—*keepin' books*. He never sets down no accounts.—He hates,
The worst of all, collectin' debts—the worst, the more he waits.—
I've knowed him, when at last he *had* to dun a man, to end
By makin' him a loan—and mad he hadn't more to lend.

LVIII

When Pence's
 Drug
 Store
 ust to
 be in
 full
 blast,
 they
 wuz
 some
 Doc's patients
 got
 things
 frekan
 tly
 there,
 charge
 d to
 him, i
 gum!



Doc run a bill
 there, don't you know, and allus when he squared,
 He never questioned nothin',—so he had his feelin's spared.

LIX

Now sich as that, I hold and claim, hain't 'scusable—it's not
Perfessional!—It's jes a shame 'at Doc hisse'f hain't got
 No better *business*-sense! That's why lots 'd respect him more,
 And not give him the clean go-by fer *other* doctors. Shore!

LX

This-here Doc *Glenn*, fer instance; er this little jack-leg *Hall*;—
 They're *business*—folks respects 'em fer their *business* more 'n all

They ever knowed, er ever *will*, 'bout *medicine*.—Yit they
Collect their money, k-yore er kill.—They're *business*, anyway!



LXI

You ast Jake Dunn;—he's worked it out in *figgers*.—He kin show
Stastistics how Doc's airnt about *three* fortunes in a row,—
Ever' ten-year' hand-runnin' straight—*three* of 'em—*thirty* year'
'At Jake kin count and 'lucidate o' Sifers' practice here.

LXII

Yit—"Praise the Lord," says Doc, "we've got our little home!" says
he—
"(It's raily *Winniferd's*, but what she owns, she sheers with me.)
We' got our little gyarden-spot, and peach- and apple-trees,
And stable, too, and chicken-lot, and eighteen hive' o' bees."

LXIII

You call it anything you please, but it's *witchcraft*—the power
'At Sifers has o' handlin' bees!—He'll watch 'em by the hour—

Mix right amongst
 'em, mad and
 hot and
 swarmin'!—
 yit they
 won't
Sting *him*, er want
 to—'pear to
 not,—at least
 I know they
 don't.

LXIV

With *me* and bees
 they's no
 p'tense o'
 social-bility
 —

A dad-burn bee 'u'd
 climb a
 fence to git a whack at *me*!
I s'pose no thing 'at's *got* a sting is railly satisfied
It's *sharp* enough, ontel, i jing! he's honed it on my hide!



LXV

And Doc he's allus had a knack *inventin'* things.—Dee-vised
A windlass wound its own se'f back as it run down: and s'prised
Their new hired girl with *clothes-line*, too, and *clothes-pins*, all in
 one:
Purt'-nigh all left fer *her* to do wuz git her *primpin'* done!

LXVI

And onc't, I mind, in
 airly Spring,
 and tappin'
 sugar-trees,
Doc made a dad-
 burn little
 thing to
 sharpen
 spiles with—
 these-
Here wood'-spouts
 'at the peth's
 punched out,
 and driv' in
 where they
 bore
The auger-holes. He
 sharpened
 'bout *a*
 million
 spiles er
 more!



LXVII

And Doc's the first man ever swung a *bucket* on a tree
Instid o' *troughs*; and first man brung *grained* sugar—so's 'at he
Could use it fer his coffee, and fer cookin', don't you know.—
Folks come clean up from Pleasantland 'fore they'd *believe* it,
though!

LXVIII

And all Doc's stable-doors *onlocks* and locks *theirse'ves*—and gates
The same way;—all rigged up like clocks, with pulleys, wheels, and
weights,—
So, 's Doc says, "drivin' *out*, er *in*, they'll *open*; and they'll *then*,
All quiet-like, shet up ag'in like little gentlemen!"

LXIX

And Doc 'ud made a mighty good *detective*.—Neighbors all
Will testify to *that*—er *could*, ef they wuz legal call:
His theories on any crime is worth your listenin' to.—
And he has hit 'em, many a time, 'long 'fore established true.

LXX

At this young druggist Wenfield Pence's trial fer his life,
On *primy faishy* evidence o' pizonin' his wife,
Doc's testimony saved and cle'red and 'quitted him and freed
Him so 's he never even 'peared cog-*nizant* of the deed!

LXXI

The facts wuz—Sifers testified,—at inquest he had found
The stummick showed the woman *died* o' pizon, but had downed
The dos't *herse'f*,—because *amount* and *cost* o' drug employed

No *druggist* would, on *no*
account, a-lavished
and distroyed!

LXXII

Doc tracked a blame-don
burgler down, and
nailed the scamp, to
boot,
But told him ef he'd leave
the town he wouldn't
prosecute.
He traced him by a tied-up
thumb-print in fresh
putty, where
Doc glazed it. Jes *that's* how
he come to track him
to his lair!



LXXIII

Doc's jes a *leetle* too inclined, *some* thinks, to overlook
The criminal and vicious kind we'd ort to bring to book
And punish, 'thout no extry show o' *sympathizin'*, where
They hain't showed none fer *us*, you know. But he takes issue there:



Doc argies 'at "The Red-eyed Law," as *he* says, "ort to learn
To lay a mighty leenient paw on deeds o' sich concern
As only the Good Bein' knows the wherefore of, and spreads
His hands above accused and sows His mercies on their heads."

LXXV

Doc even holds 'at *murder* hain't no crime we got a right
To *hang* a man fer—claims it's *taint* o' *lunacy*, er *quite*.—
"Hold *sich* a man responsibul fer murder," Doc says,—"then,
When *he's* hung, where's the rope to pull them *sound-mind*
jurymen?"

LXXVI

"It's in a nutshell—*all* kin see," says Doc,—"*it's* cle'r the *Law's*
As ap' to err as you er me, and kill without a cause:
The man most innocent o' sin *I've* saw, er '*spect* to see,
Wuz servin' a life-sentence in the penitentchury."

LXXVII

And Doc's a whole hand at a *fire*!—directin' how and where
To set your ladders, low er higher, and what first duties air,—
Like formin' warter-bucket-line; and best man in the town
To chop holes in old roofs, and mine defective chimblies down:

LXXVIII

Er durin' any public crowd, mass-meetin', er big day,
Where ladies ortn't be allowed, as I've heerd Sifers say,—
When they's a suddent rush somewhere, it's Doc's voice, ca'm and
cle'r,
Says, "Fall back, men, and give her air!— that's all she's faintin'
fer."



The sorriest I ever feel fer Doc is when some show
Er circus comes to town and he'll not git a chance to go.
'Cause he jes natchurly *delights* in circuses—clean down
From tumblers, in their spangled tights, to trick-mule and Old
Clown.

LXXX

And ever'body *knows* it, too, how Doc is, thataway!...
I mind a circus onc't come through—wuz there myse'f that day.—
Ringmaster cracked his whip, you know, to start the ridin'—when
In runs Old Clown and hollers "*Whoa!*—Ladies and gentlemen

LXXXI

"Of this vast audience, I fain would make *inquiry* cle'r,
And learn, find out, and ascertain—*Is Doctor Sifers here?*"
And when some fool-voice bellers down: "He is! He's settin' in
Full view o' ye!" "*Then,*" says the Clown, "*the circus may begin!*"

LXXXII

Doc's got a *temper*; but, he says, he's learnt it which is boss,
Yit has to *watch* it, more er less.... I never seen him cross
But onc't, enough to make him swear;—milch-cow stepped on his
toe,
And Doc ripped out "*I doggies!*"—There's the only case I know.

LXXXIII

Doc says that's what your temper's fer—to hold back out o' view,
And learn it never to occur on out ahead o' *you*.—
"*You* lead the way," says Sifers—"git your *temper* back in line—
And *furdest* back the *best*, ef it's as mean a one as mine!"

LXXXIV

He hates
contenti
ons—
can't
abide a
wrangle
er
dispute
O' any kind; and
he 'ull
slide out
of a
crowd
and
skoot
Up some back-
alley
'fore
he'll
stand
and listen to a furse



When ary one's got upper-hand and t' other one's got worse.

LXXXV

Doc says: "I 'spise, when pore and weak and awk'ard talkers fails,
To see it's them with hardest cheek and loudest mouth prevails.—
A' all-one-sided quarr'l'll make me *biased*, mighty near,—
'Cause ginerly the side I take's the one I never hear."

LXXXVI

What 'peals to Doc the most and best is "seein' folks *agreed*,
And takin' ekal interest and universal heed

O' ever'body *else's* words
and idies—same
as we
Wuz glad and chirpy as
the birds—jes as
we'd *ort* to be!"

LXXXVII

And *paterotic*! Like to
git Doc started,
full and fair,
About the war, and why
't 'uz fit, and what
wuz 'complished
there;
"And who wuz *wrong*,"
says Doc, "er
right, 't 'uz waste
o' blood and
tears,

All prophesied in *Black and White* fer years and years and years!"



LXXXVIII

And then he'll likely kind o' tetch on old John Brown, and dwell
On what *his* warnin's wuz; and ketch his breath and cough, and tell
On down to Lincoln's death. And *then*—well, he jes chokes and
quits

With "I must go now, gentlemen!" and grabs his hat, and *gits*!

LXXXIX

Doc's own war-rickord wuzn't won so much in line o' fight
As line o' work and nussin' done the wownded, day and night.—

His wuz the hand, through dark and dawn, 'at bound their wownds,
and laid
As soft as their own mother's on their forreds when they prayed....

XC

His wuz the face they
saw the first—all
dim, but smilin'
bright,
As they come to and
knowed the
worst, yit saw the
old *Red-White-*
And-Blue where Doc had
fixed it where
they'd see it
wavin' still,
Out through the open
tent-flap there, er
'cros't the winder-
sill.



XCI

And some's a-limpin' round here yit—a-waitin' Last Review,—
'U'd give the pensions 'at they git, and pawn their crutches, too,
To he'p Doc out, ef he wuz pressed financial'—same as he
Has *allus* he'pped them when distressed—ner never tuk a fee.



XCII

Doc never wuz much hand to pay attention to *p'tence*
And fuss-and-feathers and display in men o' prominence:
"A railly *great* man," Sifers 'lows, "is not the out'ard dressed—
All uniform, salutes and bows, and swellin' out his chest.

XCIII

"I *met* a great man onc't," Doc says, "and shuk his hand," says he,
"And *he* come 'bout in *one*, I guess, o' disapp'intin' *me*—
He talked so common-like, and brought his mind so cle'r in view
And simple-like, I put'-nigh thought, '*I'm* best man o' the two!'"

XCIV

Yes-*sir*! Doc's got convictions and old-fashioned kind o' ways
And idies 'bout this glorious Land o' Freedom; and he'll raise
His hat clean off, no matter where, jes ever' time he sees
The Stars and Stripes a-floatin' there and flappin' in the breeze.

XCV

And tunes like old
 "Red, White
 and Blue" 'll
 fairly drive
 him wild,
 Played on the brass
 band,
 marchin'
 through the
 streets! Jes
 like a child
 I've saw that man, his
 smile jes set,
 all kind o'
 pale and
 white,
 Bare-headed, and his
 eyes all wet,
 yit dancin'
 with delight!



XCVI

And yit, that very man we see all trimbly, pale and wann,
 Give him a case o' *surgery*, we'll see another man!—
 We'll do the trimblin' then, and we'll git white around the gills—
 He'll show us *nerve* o' nerves, and he 'ull show us *skill* o' skills!

XCVII

Then you could toot your horns and beat your drums and bang your
 guns,
 And wave your flags and march the street, and charge, all Freedom's
 sons!—
 And Sifers *then*, I bet my hat, 'u'd never flinch a hair,
 But, stiddy-handed, 'tend to that pore patient layin' there.

XCVIII

And Sifers' eye's as stiddy
as that hand o' his!
—He'll shoot
A' old-style rifle, like he
has, and smallest
bore, to boot,
With any fancy rifles
made to-day, er
expert shot
'At works at shootin' like a
trade—and all
some of 'em's got!



XCIX

Let 'em go right out in the
woods with Doc,
and leave their
"traps"
And blame glass-balls and
queensware-goods, and see how Sifers draps
A squirrel out the tallest tree.—And 'fore he fires he'll say
Jes where he'll hit him—yes, sir-ee! And he's hit thataway!

C

Let 'em go out with him, i jucks! with fishin'-pole and gun,—
And ekal chances, fish and ducks, and take the *rain*, er *sun*,
Jes as it pours, er as it blinds the eye-sight; *then*, I guess,
'At they'd acknowledge, in their minds, their disadvantages.

CI

And yit *he'd* be the last
man out to flop
his wings and
crow
Insultin'-like, and strut
about above his
fallen foe!—
No-*sir*! the hand 'at tuk
the wind out o'
their sails 'ud
be
The very first they
grabbed, and
grinned to feel
sich sympathy.



CII

Doc gits off now and
then and takes a
huntin'-trip
somewhere
'Bout Kankakee, up 'mongst the lakes—sometimes'll drift round
there
In his canoe a week er two; then paddle clean on back
By way o' old Wabash and Blue, with fish—all he kin pack,—

CIII

And wild ducks—some with feathers on 'em yit, and stuffed with
grass.
And neighbors—all knows he's bin *gone*—comes round and gits a
bass—
A great big double-breasted "rock," er "black," er maybe *pair*
Half fills a' ordinary crock.... Doc's *fish*'ll give out there

CIV

Long 'fore his
 ducks!—But
 folks'll smile
 and blandish
 him, and
 make
Him tell and *tell*
 things!—all
 the while
 enjoy 'em
 jes fer sake
O' pleasin' *him*; and
 then turn in
 and la'nch
 him from the
 start
A-tellin' all the
 things ag'in
 they railly
 know by
 heart.



CV

He's jes a *child*, 's what Sifers is! And-sir, I'd ruther see
That happy, childish face o' his, and puore simplicity,
Than any shape er style er plan o' mortals otherwise—
With perfect faith in God and man a-shinin' in his eyes.



TAMÁM.

Transcriber's Note:

All variations in spelling, inconsistent hyphenation and spelling have been retained as they appear in the original text.

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK RUBÁIYÁT OF
DOC SIFERS ***

Updated editions will replace the previous one—the old editions will be renamed.

Creating the works from print editions not protected by U.S. copyright law means that no one owns a United States copyright in these works, so the Foundation (and you!) can copy and distribute it in the United States without permission and without paying copyright royalties. Special rules, set forth in the General Terms of Use part of this license, apply to copying and distributing Project Gutenberg™ electronic works to protect the PROJECT GUTENBERG™ concept and trademark. Project Gutenberg is a registered trademark, and may not be used if you charge for an eBook, except by following the terms of the trademark license, including paying royalties for use of the Project Gutenberg trademark. If you do not charge anything for copies of this eBook, complying with the trademark license is very easy. You may use this eBook for nearly any purpose such as creation of derivative works, reports, performances and research. Project Gutenberg eBooks may be modified and printed and given away—you may do practically ANYTHING in the United States with eBooks not protected by U.S. copyright law. Redistribution is subject to the trademark license, especially commercial redistribution.

START: FULL LICENSE

THE FULL PROJECT GUTENBERG™ LICENSE

PLEASE READ THIS BEFORE YOU DISTRIBUTE OR USE THIS WORK

To protect the Project Gutenberg™ mission of promoting the free distribution of electronic works, by using or distributing this work (or any other work associated in any way with the phrase “Project Gutenberg”), you agree to comply with all the terms of the Full Project Gutenberg License available with this file or online at www.gutenberg.org/license.

Section 1. General Terms of Use and Redistributing Project Gutenberg electronic works

1.A. By reading or using any part of this Project Gutenberg electronic work, you indicate that you have read, understand, agree to and accept all the terms of this license and intellectual property (trademark/copyright) agreement. If you do not agree to abide by all the terms of this agreement, you must cease using and return or destroy all copies of Project Gutenberg electronic works in your possession. If you paid a fee for obtaining a copy of or access to a Project Gutenberg electronic work and you do not agree to be bound by the terms of this agreement, you may obtain a refund from the person or entity to whom you paid the fee as set forth in paragraph 1.E.8.

1.B. “Project Gutenberg” is a registered trademark. It may only be used on or associated in any way with an electronic work by people who agree to be bound by the terms of this agreement. There are a few things that you can do with most Project Gutenberg electronic works even without complying with the full terms of this agreement. See paragraph 1.C below. There are a lot of things you can do with Project Gutenberg electronic works if you follow the terms of this agreement and help preserve free future access to Project Gutenberg electronic works. See paragraph 1.E below.

1.C. The Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation (“the Foundation” or PGLAF), owns a compilation copyright in the collection of Project Gutenberg electronic works. Nearly all the individual works in the collection are in the public domain in the United States. If an individual work is unprotected by copyright law in the United States and you are

located in the United States, we do not claim a right to prevent you from copying, distributing, performing, displaying or creating derivative works based on the work as long as all references to Project Gutenberg are removed. Of course, we hope that you will support the Project Gutenberg mission of promoting free access to electronic works by freely sharing Project Gutenberg works in compliance with the terms of this agreement for keeping the Project Gutenberg name associated with the work. You can easily comply with the terms of this agreement by keeping this work in the same format with its attached full Project Gutenberg License when you share it without charge with others.

1.D. The copyright laws of the place where you are located also govern what you can do with this work. Copyright laws in most countries are in a constant state of change. If you are outside the United States, check the laws of your country in addition to the terms of this agreement before downloading, copying, displaying, performing, distributing or creating derivative works based on this work or any other Project Gutenberg work. The Foundation makes no representations concerning the copyright status of any work in any country other than the United States.

1.E. Unless you have removed all references to Project Gutenberg:

1.E.1. The following sentence, with active links to, or other immediate access to, the full Project Gutenberg License must appear prominently whenever any copy of a Project Gutenberg work (any work on which the phrase “Project Gutenberg” appears, or with which the phrase “Project Gutenberg” is associated) is accessed, displayed, performed, viewed, copied or distributed:

This eBook is for the use of anyone anywhere in the United States and most other parts of the world at no cost and with almost no restrictions whatsoever. You may copy it, give it away or re-use it under the terms of the Project Gutenberg™ License included with this eBook or online at www.gutenberg.org. If you are not located in the United States, you will have to check the laws of the country where you are located before using this eBook.

1.E.2. If an individual Project Gutenberg electronic work is derived from texts not protected by U.S. copyright law (does not contain a notice indicating that it is posted with permission of the copyright holder), the work can be copied and distributed to anyone in the United States without paying any fees or charges. If you are redistributing or providing access to a work with the phrase “Project Gutenberg” associated with or appearing on the work, you must comply either with the requirements of paragraphs 1.E.1 through 1.E.7 or obtain permission for the use of the work and the Project Gutenberg trademark as set forth in paragraphs 1.E.8 or 1.E.9.

1.E.3. If an individual Project Gutenberg electronic work is posted with the permission of the copyright holder, your use and distribution must comply with both paragraphs 1.E.1 through 1.E.7 and any additional terms imposed by the copyright holder. Additional terms will be linked to the Project Gutenberg License for all works posted with the permission of the copyright holder found at the beginning of this work.

1.E.4. Do not unlink or detach or remove the full Project Gutenberg License terms from this work, or any files containing a part of this work or any other work associated with Project Gutenberg.

1.E.5. Do not copy, display, perform, distribute or redistribute this electronic work, or any part of this electronic work, without prominently displaying the sentence set forth in paragraph 1.E.1 with active links or immediate access to the full terms of the Project Gutenberg License.

1.E.6. You may convert to and distribute this work in any binary, compressed, marked up, nonproprietary or proprietary form, including any word processing or hypertext form. However, if you provide access to or distribute copies of a Project Gutenberg work in a format other than “Plain Vanilla ASCII” or other format used in the official version posted on the official Project Gutenberg website (www.gutenberg.org), you must, at no additional cost, fee or expense to the user, provide a copy, a means of exporting a copy, or a means of obtaining a copy upon request, of the work in its original “Plain Vanilla ASCII” or other form. Any alternate format must include the full Project Gutenberg License as specified in paragraph 1.E.1.

1.E.7. Do not charge a fee for access to, viewing, displaying, performing, copying or distributing any Project Gutenberg works unless you comply with paragraph 1.E.8 or 1.E.9.

1.E.8. You may charge a reasonable fee for copies of or providing access to or distributing Project Gutenberg electronic works provided that:

- You pay a royalty fee of 20% of the gross profits you derive from the use of Project Gutenberg works calculated using the method you already use to calculate your applicable taxes. The fee is owed to the owner of the Project Gutenberg trademark, but he has agreed to donate royalties under this paragraph to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation. Royalty payments must be paid within 60 days following each date on which you prepare (or are legally required to prepare) your periodic tax returns. Royalty payments should be clearly marked as such and sent to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation at the address specified in Section 4, "Information about donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation."
- You provide a full refund of any money paid by a user who notifies you in writing (or by e-mail) within 30 days of receipt that s/he does not agree to the terms of the full Project Gutenberg™ License. You must require such a user to return or destroy all copies of the works possessed in a physical medium and discontinue all use of and all access to other copies of Project Gutenberg™ works.
- You provide, in accordance with paragraph 1.F.3, a full refund of any money paid for a work or a replacement copy, if a defect in the electronic work is discovered and reported to you within 90 days of receipt of the work.
- You comply with all other terms of this agreement for free distribution of Project Gutenberg™ works.

1.E.9. If you wish to charge a fee or distribute a Project Gutenberg™ electronic work or group of works on different terms than are set forth in this agreement, you must obtain permission in writing from the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, the manager of the Project

Gutenberg™ trademark. Contact the Foundation as set forth in Section 3 below.

1.F.

1.F.1. Project Gutenberg volunteers and employees expend considerable effort to identify, do copyright research on, transcribe and proofread works not protected by U.S. copyright law in creating the Project Gutenberg™ collection. Despite these efforts, Project Gutenberg™ electronic works, and the medium on which they may be stored, may contain “Defects,” such as, but not limited to, incomplete, inaccurate or corrupt data, transcription errors, a copyright or other intellectual property infringement, a defective or damaged disk or other medium, a computer virus, or computer codes that damage or cannot be read by your equipment.

1.F.2. LIMITED WARRANTY, DISCLAIMER OF DAMAGES - Except for the “Right of Replacement or Refund” described in paragraph 1.F.3, the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, the owner of the Project Gutenberg™ trademark, and any other party distributing a Project Gutenberg™ electronic work under this agreement, disclaim all liability to you for damages, costs and expenses, including legal fees. YOU AGREE THAT YOU HAVE NO REMEDIES FOR NEGLIGENCE, STRICT LIABILITY, BREACH OF WARRANTY OR BREACH OF CONTRACT EXCEPT THOSE PROVIDED IN PARAGRAPH 1.F.3. YOU AGREE THAT THE FOUNDATION, THE TRADEMARK OWNER, AND ANY DISTRIBUTOR UNDER THIS AGREEMENT WILL NOT BE LIABLE TO YOU FOR ACTUAL, DIRECT, INDIRECT, CONSEQUENTIAL, PUNITIVE OR INCIDENTAL DAMAGES EVEN IF YOU GIVE NOTICE OF THE POSSIBILITY OF SUCH DAMAGE.

1.F.3. LIMITED RIGHT OF REPLACEMENT OR REFUND - If you discover a defect in this electronic work within 90 days of receiving it, you can receive a refund of the money (if any) you paid for it by sending a written explanation to the person you received the work from. If you received the work on a physical medium, you must return the medium with your written explanation. The person or entity that provided you with the defective work may elect to provide a replacement copy in lieu of a refund. If you received the work electronically, the person or entity providing it to

you may choose to give you a second opportunity to receive the work electronically in lieu of a refund. If the second copy is also defective, you may demand a refund in writing without further opportunities to fix the problem.

1.F.4. Except for the limited right of replacement or refund set forth in paragraph 1.F.3, this work is provided to you 'AS-IS', WITH NO OTHER WARRANTIES OF ANY KIND, EXPRESS OR IMPLIED, INCLUDING BUT NOT LIMITED TO WARRANTIES OF MERCHANTABILITY OR FITNESS FOR ANY PURPOSE.

1.F.5. Some states do not allow disclaimers of certain implied warranties or the exclusion or limitation of certain types of damages. If any disclaimer or limitation set forth in this agreement violates the law of the state applicable to this agreement, the agreement shall be interpreted to make the maximum disclaimer or limitation permitted by the applicable state law. The invalidity or unenforceability of any provision of this agreement shall not void the remaining provisions.

1.F.6. INDEMNITY - You agree to indemnify and hold the Foundation, the trademark owner, any agent or employee of the Foundation, anyone providing copies of Project Gutenberg™ electronic works in accordance with this agreement, and any volunteers associated with the production, promotion and distribution of Project Gutenberg™ electronic works, harmless from all liability, costs and expenses, including legal fees, that arise directly or indirectly from any of the following which you do or cause to occur: (a) distribution of this or any Project Gutenberg work, (b) alteration, modification, or additions or deletions to any Project Gutenberg work, and (c) any Defect you cause.

Section 2. Information about the Mission of Project Gutenberg

Project Gutenberg is synonymous with the free distribution of electronic works in formats readable by the widest variety of computers including obsolete, old, middle-aged and new computers. It exists because of the

efforts of hundreds of volunteers and donations from people in all walks of life.

Volunteers and financial support to provide volunteers with the assistance they need are critical to reaching Project Gutenberg's goals and ensuring that the Project Gutenberg collection will remain freely available for generations to come. In 2001, the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation was created to provide a secure and permanent future for Project Gutenberg and future generations. To learn more about the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation and how your efforts and donations can help, see Sections 3 and 4 and the Foundation information page at www.gutenberg.org.

Section 3. Information about the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation

The Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation is a non-profit 501(c)(3) educational corporation organized under the laws of the state of Mississippi and granted tax exempt status by the Internal Revenue Service. The Foundation's EIN or federal tax identification number is 64-6221541. Contributions to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation are tax deductible to the full extent permitted by U.S. federal laws and your state's laws.

The Foundation's business office is located at 41 Watchung Plaza #516, Montclair NJ 07042, USA, +1 (862) 621-9288. Email contact links and up to date contact information can be found at the Foundation's website and official page at www.gutenberg.org/contact

Section 4. Information about Donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation

Project Gutenberg™ depends upon and cannot survive without widespread public support and donations to carry out its mission of increasing the number of public domain and licensed works that can be freely distributed in machine-readable form accessible by the widest array of equipment

including outdated equipment. Many small donations (\$1 to \$5,000) are particularly important to maintaining tax exempt status with the IRS.

The Foundation is committed to complying with the laws regulating charities and charitable donations in all 50 states of the United States. Compliance requirements are not uniform and it takes a considerable effort, much paperwork and many fees to meet and keep up with these requirements. We do not solicit donations in locations where we have not received written confirmation of compliance. To SEND DONATIONS or determine the status of compliance for any particular state visit www.gutenberg.org/donate.

While we cannot and do not solicit contributions from states where we have not met the solicitation requirements, we know of no prohibition against accepting unsolicited donations from donors in such states who approach us with offers to donate.

International donations are gratefully accepted, but we cannot make any statements concerning tax treatment of donations received from outside the United States. U.S. laws alone swamp our small staff.

Please check the Project Gutenberg web pages for current donation methods and addresses. Donations are accepted in a number of other ways including checks, online payments and credit card donations. To donate, please visit: www.gutenberg.org/donate.

Section 5. General Information About Project Gutenberg electronic works

Professor Michael S. Hart was the originator of the Project Gutenberg concept of a library of electronic works that could be freely shared with anyone. For forty years, he produced and distributed Project Gutenberg eBooks with only a loose network of volunteer support.

Project Gutenberg eBooks are often created from several printed editions, all of which are confirmed as not protected by copyright in the U.S. unless a

copyright notice is included. Thus, we do not necessarily keep eBooks in compliance with any particular paper edition.

Most people start at our website which has the main PG search facility:
www.gutenberg.org.

This website includes information about Project Gutenberg, including how to make donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, how to help produce our new eBooks, and how to subscribe to our email newsletter to hear about new eBooks.